



The

Sacred Tome

of

Strahd (Von Zarovich)

Count of Barovia

and Lord of

Castle Ravenloft

I am the Ancient.

I am the Land.

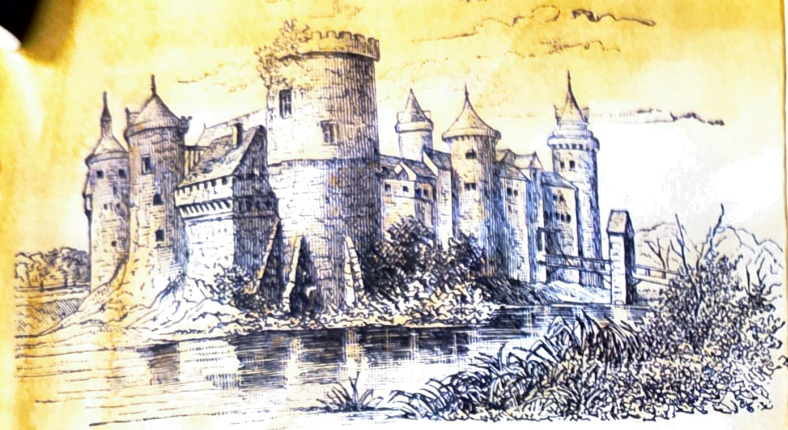
My beginnings are lost in the
darkness of the past. I was the
warrior, I was good and just. I
thundered across the land like the
wrath of a just god, but the war
years and the killing years wore

down my soul as the wind wears
stone into sand.

All goodness slipped from my
life. I found my youth and strength
gone, and all I had left was death.

My army settled in the valley of
Barovia and took power over the
people in the name of a just god, but
with none of a god's grace or justice.





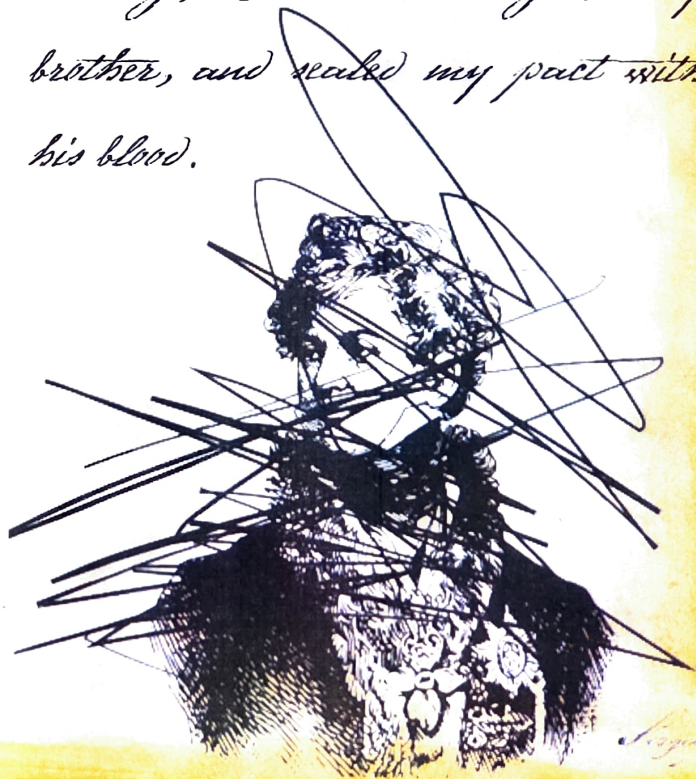
I called for my family, long
unseated from their ancient thrones,
and brought them here to settle in
the castle Ravenloft. They came
with a younger brother of mine,
Sergei. He was handsome and
youthful. I hated him for both.

From the families of the valley,
one spirit shone above all others: a
rare beauty, who was called
'perfection,' 'joy,' and 'treasure.'
Her name was Tatyana, and I
longed for her to be mine. But 'Old
One' was my name to her — 'elder'
and 'brother' also. Her heart went
to Sergei. They were betrothed. The
date was set.

With words
she called me
"brother," but
when I looked
into her eyes they
reflected another
name: "death." It was the death
of the aged that she saw in me. She
loved her youth and enjoyed it, but I
had squandered mine. And so I
came to hate death—my death.



But I would not be called
"death" so soon. I made a pact
with Death. On the day of the
wedding, I killed Sergei, my
brother, and sealed my pact with
his blood.

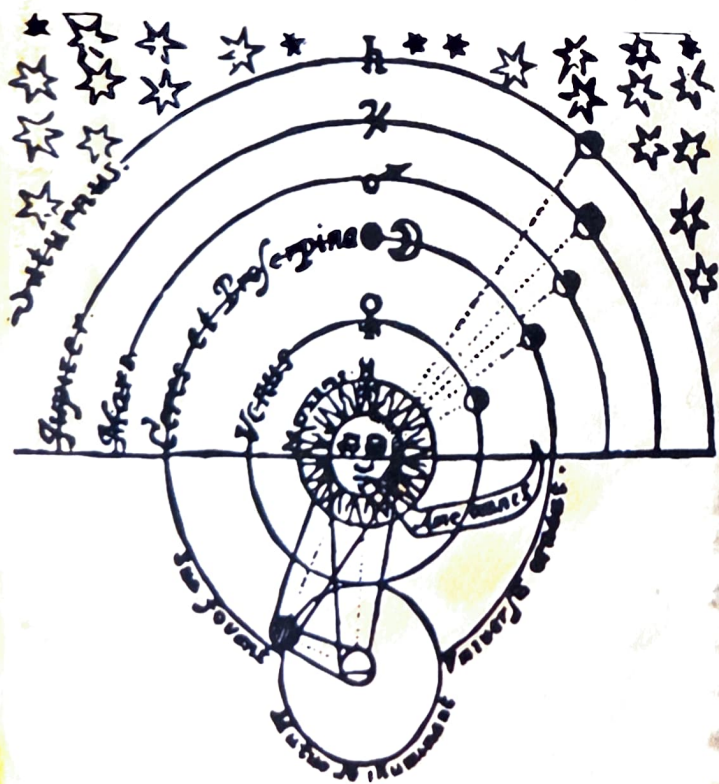


I found Tatyana weeping in the garden east of the chapel. She fled from me, and I pursued. Finally, in despair, she flung herself from the walls of Ravenloft, and I watched everything I ever wanted fall from my grasp forever.

It was a thousand feet through the mists. No trace of her was ever found, and not even I know her final fate. Arrows from the castle

guards pierced me to my soul, but I did not die. Nor did I live. I became undead, forever.

I have studied much since then.
 'Vampyr' is my new name. I still
 last for life and youth, and I curse
 the living that took them from me.



Even the sun is against me, but
 little else can harm me now. Even
 a stake through my heart does not
 kill me, though it holds me from
 movement. But the sword, that
 cursed sword that Sergei brought! I
 must dispose
 of that awful
 tool! I fear
 and hate it
 as much as
 the sun.



I have learned much, too, about
this land of Barovia. Ancient are
its ways, ancient beyond the
knowledge of the simple folk of the
valley. Ancient gods dwell in this
valley long before my coming, and
three hidden fanes still give tribute
to their memories. I visited the
Swamp fane, the forest fane, and
the Mountain fane, and claimed
their power for my own. Their

servants now serve me, and thus I
have become the Lord.

Since my passage into eternity,
I have often hunted for Tatyana. I
have even felt her within my grasp,
though she fled from me once again.
But she cannot run forever — and I
have nothing but time.



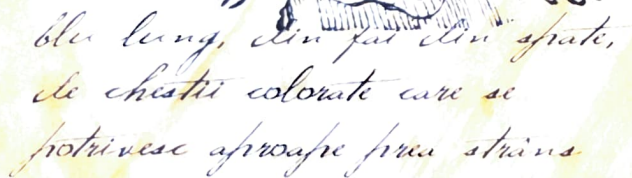
I write this now to crystallize my
rage in the face of time's bitter
winds. As the chill of the grave
grips my heart, I feel all that I
was leave me—the death of the
man, and the birth of the
immortal. Yet this memory shall
persevere, a scion of that righteous
fury. I shall bury the past, and so
begin anew.

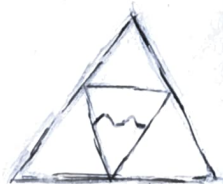
I now reside far below
Ravenloft. I live among the dead

and sleep beneath the very stones of
this hollow castle of despair. I have
abandoned the riches of my
conquests beneath the toll of the
belfry, sealed behind a reminder of
the treasure I once lost. Yet one day,
I shall rise again from the ashes of
my glory and reclaim what is
rightfully mine.



For more of these go to the shop

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Expt 10